

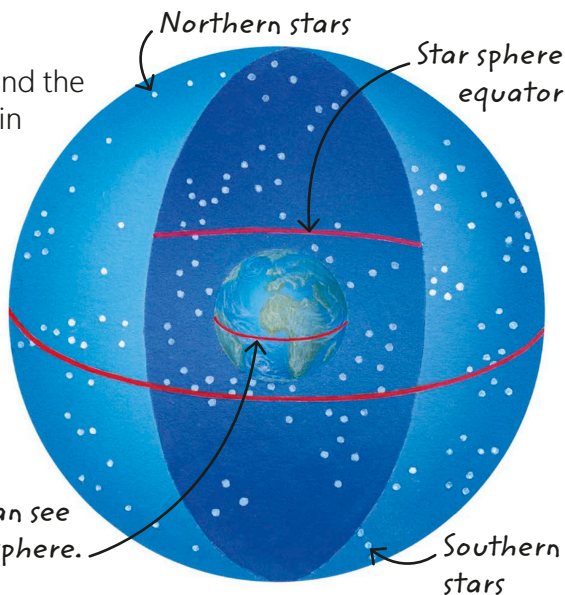
Dots of light

As we look into space, we see lots of twinkling dots of light. These are huge stars, but because they are so far away they just look like bright specks in a dark sky. It seems as if the Earth is inside a gigantic sphere covered in stars.

The dividing line

The equator, an imaginary line around the middle of Earth, divides our world in two. The top half is the Northern Hemisphere and the bottom half is the Southern Hemisphere. The sphere of stars also has an equator dividing it into two halves. You can see mainly northern stars from the Northern Hemisphere and southern stars from the Southern Hemisphere.

If you live near the equator, you can see stars from both halves of the star sphere.



Traveling light

Light travels faster than anything else, but stars are so far away from us that their light takes years to reach Earth. Scientists who study the stars and planets can see distant galaxies whose light started traveling toward us when dinosaurs lived on Earth.

